

To Last Long or to Fade Away: Investigating Users' Instagram Post and Story Practices

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ABSTRACT

In this study, we examined how users strategically leveraged the two affordances, content persistence and ephemerality, for self-presentation and relationship maintenance on Instagram. In contrast to other social media platforms that usually support either persistent (e.g., Twitter) or transient content sharing (e.g., Snapchat), Instagram affords both functions through regular posts and short-lived Story. We conducted a seven-day diary study on Instagram users ($n=13$) and used the data as probes for follow-up in-depth one-on-one interview. Our findings show that people deliberately curated persistent posts to present their ideal images. In contrast, ephemeral Story shows more authentic and casual sides of self. With the interpersonal and ephemeral touch, Story creates more private and directed engagement among users and their audiences than the interactions derived from posts. Story also helps users develop deeper relationships and extended interaction with others without experiencing “context-collapse.”

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1 INTRODUCTION

Launched in 2010, Instagram is a mobile social application featuring photo-sharing. Instagram first differentiated itself from other social media as a platform that helps user transform their photos into lasting memories [2]. With the social media affordances of persistence and recordability [3], Instagram posts can be kept as persistent contents for purposes like self-presentation [6], social-interaction, or curation [2], which can be deleted only if users wish to do so.

In contrast to regular posts that are persistent, Story is a function implemented by Instagram in 2016, encouraging users to share ephemeral moments on the fly. Instagram Story allows user to share photos or videos, which last shorter and disappear automatically after 24 hours. The Story function that carries ephemeral video

was first introduced by Snapchat, a social media famous for short-lived contents only, in 2013 and was followed by many other social media after its success. Facebook implemented Facebook Story in 2017 and Twitter launched Twitter Fleet in 2020. While more and more social media afford both practices of persistent and ephemeral content management, Instagram was the first that incorporated the two, which makes Instagram a suitable platform for academic investigation into concurrent ephemeral and persistent content management. According to the latest statistical report [13], compared with Facebook Story, Instagram Story has higher adoption.

Previous literature has investigated users' perceptions and practices around persistent or ephemeral social media affordance, respectively (e.g., [1, 4, 5]). For example, Bayer et al. discussed about ephemerality on Snapchat, pointing out that Snapchat messages or stories are spontaneous contents that can encourage users to share more lightweight and daily experiences and reduce the insecurity of self-presentation [1]. Other works mentioned that the contents on ephemeral platforms have been through less self-scrutiny by users than those on the persistent platforms [4, 5]. Few research looks into how and why users make sense of the two functions when offered concurrently by the same application. Using qualitative research methods, including diary study and in-depth interview, with 13 participants, the goal of the study is to examine 1) how users leverage the two affordances, posts and Stories, to manage their Instagram content for different purposes; and 2) how people perceive, behave, and interact with the audience through persistent or ephemeral contents.

2 SOCIAL MEDIA AFFORDANCES AND SELF-PRESENTATION

Persistence on social media refers to the extent to which the availability of information (posts/blogs) can be traceable or stay apparent over time [3]. With persistent contents, users can access, retrieve, and interact with the posts for an extended period of time. Users can also archive their posts for reasons like self-presentation or content curation [7]. However, the phenomenon of “context collapse” [9] where various social networks previously separated by temporal or spatial boundaries in offline settings coexist on social media platforms makes it difficult for users to manage persistent contents due to unintended information disclosure and contradictory self-presentation [1].

On the other hand, the ephemerality of social media indicates that the content users publish only lasts for a limited period of time. Take Snapchat or Instagram Story for example. Users share snippets of their life updates with their audience on the platforms and the contents only last a few seconds on Snapchat and 24 hours on Instagram. The transient nature of such content prompts users

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to share more serendipitous and real-time information [5]. The ephemerality of social media affords different benefits than permanent social media contents, such as allowing users to post more lightweight and mundane events [1]. While previous research indicates that people have both needs for persistent and ephemeral content management on social media [5], most research dealt with users' practices with one of the affordances on a single site, such as Facebook [8] or Snapchat [1]. Few studies investigate how users decide whether to leave their contents permanent or ephemeral as well as for what reasons on a single site. To complement previous studies, our research investigates users' permanent and ephemeral content management on Instagram so as to provide insights into social media designs for purposes like self-presentation and relationship maintenance.

Self-presentation is defined as the way individuals manage their images to present their ideal self through interactions with others [10]. Without visual and verbal cues, online self-presentation allows more room for users to manipulate their self-presentation(s) and therefore is tricky for others to verify the authenticity [11], not to mention the coexistence of different audience groups [9] makes it complex for users to manage a consistent image. The networking nature of social media can help users connect with other users and seek social support by interacting with others online [2]. For Instagram users, social interaction is a strong motivation for them to be on the platform in order to build and maintain interpersonal relationship on Instagram [2]. It is worthy of scholarly investigation into how users make use of permanent and ephemeral social media contents to engage in self-presentation on Instagram.

3 METHOD

3.1 Study Procedure

The study included two parts: (1) a seven-day diary, followed by (2) a semi-structured individual in-depth interview. The participants were asked to keep individual diaries for seven consecutive days. They were asked to report daily the following items in the first part of our research: (a) the number of the stories/posts they post, (b) the topics of the stories/posts, and (c) the number of feedback(emojis/likes/comments) of the stories/posts. The diary served as the basic understanding about the posting behaviors and habits of the participants on Instagram. Later, we customized part of our interview questions based on their diary entries.

After finishing the 7-day diary, the participants were asked to join one-on-one in-depth interview, each of which lasted 25 to 40 mins. Focusing on ephemeral (stories) and persistent content (posts) management on Instagram, the interviews covered the following questions as probes: (a) motivations for posting stories and posts on Instagram, (b) attitudes toward stories and posts, (c) decision processes of posting different types of contents, (d) how and why they use different types of posts to interact with audiences, and (e) how and why different types of posts enhance/weaken their relationships with their audiences.

3.2 Participants

According to the distribution of Instagram users' age worldwide as of April 2021 from Statista, 62.4% of the global Instagram users are 18 to 34 years old [12]. As a result, we targeted college students and

Table 1: In the past one week, how often did you post "Story" in an average day?

Less than one story a day	7
1~2 stories a day	4
3~4 stories a day	2

Table 2: In the past three months, how many "Posts " have you posted?

0 post	1
1~2 posts	7
5~6 posts	3
7 posts or more	2

Table 3: In the past one week, how many "Stories " in total have you posted?

Less than 5 stories	6
6~10 stories	2
11~15 stories	1
16~20 stories	3
21~25 stories	1

Table 4: In the past one week, how much time did you spend on Instagram in an average day?

Less than 30 minutes	3
30 minutes to 1 hour	3
1~2 hours	6
2~3 hours	1

young professionals as our participants in the research. Thirteen participants were recruited online and finished both two parts of the research ($M = 24.69$, $SD = 2.87$; $M = 9$, $F = 4$). Among the 13 participants, seven of them set their Instagram accounts as private, which means followers need to get approval to see their account activities. Their accounts have a number of following accounts ranging from 3 to 508 ($M = 303.38$, $SD = 144.15$) and a number of followers ranging from 0 to 1580 ($M = 338.77$, $SD = 387.01$). We asked for their general Instagram use in the recruitment questionnaire (Table 1-4).

4 RESULTS

According to the results from the diary, the common topics shared via Story related to small moments in everyday activities, such as "a strange flower seen on the way home," "burned breakfast toast," or "asking friends for borrowing a sports camera." In the case of posts, our participants had .62 posts on average in the previous week, nine of the thirteen participants did not make any post in the past one week. The topics of the posts related to monumental moments in life, including "a memorable trip to Japan last year," "Mother's Day celebration," or "going to the basketball championship game." To delve into the data, we found two major themes.

4.1 Self-Presentation

Our participants had different strategies when sharing stories and posts. Most users spent a lot of time editing the captions and the photos when sharing posts because the persistent content was used to present their ideal image, not necessarily related to their authentic self. Moreover, some of our participants saw the collection of Instagram posts as an extension of their personality and style. Therefore, they carefully curated their post content as well as filter in order to present a unique and consistent personal style. As for Story, our participants were easy on the efforts spent on curating and editing as the content was more casual, reflecting their real-self and in-the-now self-image.

"After glancing over my posts, the audience may know my style and who I want them to see, but it may not be the real me at the moment. It may be the content after I digested my feeling, or it may be the thing I wanted you to see. I enjoy managing the style and the layout of my account. As I said, when you see a person's page, you get a general idea of their lifestyle and personal image. If I have something funny in my life to share with people, I'll post it on Story, and it fades away in 24 hours. I won't have to think too much and it is more casual for me. Different from posting a story, when sharing posts, I may have to spend time choosing THE right photo. . . the left side of my face does not look good, it's too fat, or the color is not beautiful enough. Or I would think if what I want to say is too inappropriate, not politically correct or something. You can see I worry a lot when I post a post. I don't have to worry so much when posting a story." (N13, Female)

4.2 Social Interaction and Relationship Maintenance

In addition to reflecting more authentic side of self, Story can invite direct and private responses from a selected list of audience, the size of which is usually smaller than the followers of the account, so our participants consider that Story affords to bond with their audience. Users can therefore avoid interactions with followers they do not know well. Our participants indicated that the interaction modes under the story, such as GIF, polling, Q&A, and direct message help them communicate directly with their friends, bringing the relationships closer.

"I think it's(story) better for the relationship maintenance because you can't see your friends every day. With stories, you can follow up what they're doing. They can also check what I'm doing. It's easy to start a conversation. Story has a lot of functions like polling and Q&A; I think it's more effective for interaction." (N1, Female)

When the audience respond to the Story, the message goes through direct messaging channel instead of public comments. This may help address the concerns over self-presentation due to context collapse as some participants perceived to be more secured when interacting with followers on Stories than on posts. The direct and private response can secure their boundary management.

Our participants also pointed out that they were able to develop more extended conversation when responding to and exchanging message about stories. In contrast, most our participants indicated that they received fewer responses for posts. Such directed interactivity enabled by Story allows them to maintain their interpersonal relationships with their friends.

"(As a viewer), I don't really reply to posts from people I don't know well. It feels a little weird. And it also feels a little weird when people I don't know well reply to my posts. It is probably because everyone can see the response." (N10, Male)

5 CONCLUSION

Our preliminary results indicate that the public and visible features of social media platforms where potential unknown followers and collapsed social networks coexist prompt our users to edit and curate the permanent contents for ideal self-presentation on Instagram. Our users carefully orchestrate images, captions, hashtags, and filters for personal branding using permanent contents. Such seemingly laborious efforts do not necessarily attract commensurate responses as our participants pointed out that they actually posted fewer posts and their audiences less interacted with them via posts. On the other hand, the interpersonal, ephemeral, and directed features of Story encourage more social interactions among users on Instagram. Our participants reported to reveal more authentic self via Story. As they did not have to carefully present ideal images using ad-hoc strategies like filters or captions, our participants told us that they could share several Stories per day. The interactions initiated by Story are deeper and more extended.

Designs for social media platforms, especially ones like Instagram that support asymmetric friending, can consider different channels that meet users' public and private needs for presenting self as well as interacting with different types of audiences. In addition to publicly sharing and displaying ideal impressions on a mixed group of audience, alternative channels for sharing ephemeral, direct, and private responses with an adjustable list of audiences can encourage diverse and active social media use. Our study intends to continue the current effort by looking deeper into our participants' intentions and specific ways of permanent and ephemeral content engagement for individual and interactive purposes.

6 LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

Our study presents several limitations. First, social media functions can evolve. In addition to Instagram, there are also many social media platforms that support both ephemeral and persistent contents, such as WeChat, Facebook, LinkedIn, and Twitter. Although these platforms cannot be directly compared (e.g., WeChat is an instant messenger tool; LinkedIn is a professional social network site; Facebook requires symmetrical friending unlike Twitter, Instagram, LinkedIn, and WeChat, etc.), future research may further look into how these social media affordances interact with ephemeral and persistent content management from a quantitative perspective. Also, future studies can conduct in-depth comparisons and contrasts about the differences between ephemeral and persistent content management on the same application and on separate applications. We hope to continue our efforts in this topic and to

fill the research gap for more comprehensive perspectives to the community.

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